Table 8.1 Work function of some materials

Metal	Symbol	Work function (eV)	Metal	Symbol	Work function (eV)
Cesium	Cs	2.14	Aluminium	Al	4.28
Potassium	K	2.30	Mercury	Hg	4.49
Sodium	Na	2.75	Copper	Cu	4.65
Calcium	Ca	3.20	Silver	Ag	4.70
Molybdenum	Mo	4.17	Nickel	Ni	5.15
Lead	Pb	4.25	Platinum	Pt	5.65

So the metal selected for electron emission should have low work function. The electron emission is categorized into different types depending upon the form of energy being utilized. There are mainly four types of electron emission which are given below.

i) Thermionic emission

When a metal is heated to a high temperature, the free electrons on the surface of the metal get sufficient energy in the form of thermal energy so that they are emitted from the metallic surface (Figure 8.1). This type of emission is known as **thermionic emission**.

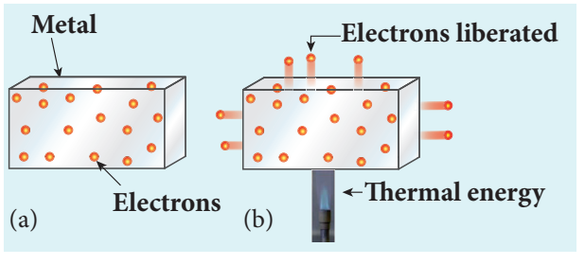


Figure 8.1 Electrons in the (a) metal (b) heated metal

The intensity of the thermionic emission (the number of electrons emitted) depends on the metal used and its temperature. **Examples:** cathode ray tubes, electron microscopes, x-ray tubes etc (Figure 8.2).

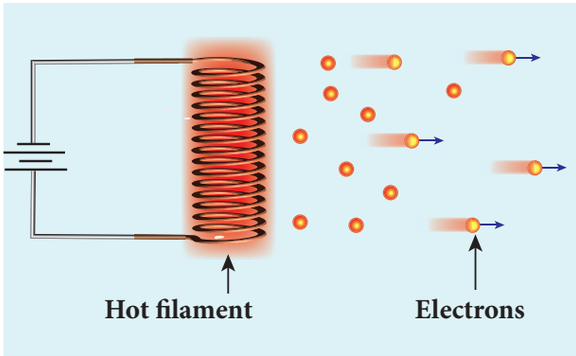


Figure 8.2 Thermionic emission from hot filament of cathode ray tube or x-ray tube

ii) Field emission

Electric field emission occurs when a very strong electric field is applied across the metal. This strong field pulls the free electrons and helps them to overcome the surface barrier of the metal (Figure 8.3). **Examples:** Field emission scanning electron microscopes, Field-emission display etc.

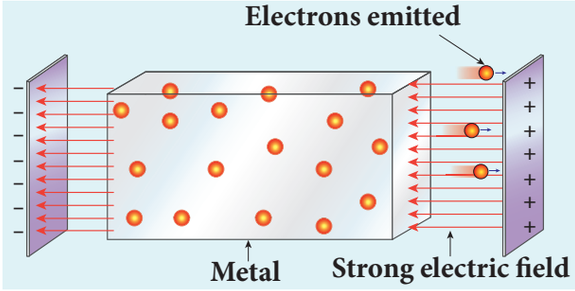


Figure 8.3 Field emission

XII_Physics_Vol-2_UNIT-8_EM.indd 110 03-03-2022 15:20:19